

Lab 10 — Exploration of IBM Watson Assistant: Lendyr Demo

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1. Preliminary Research

IBM Watson Assistant is IBM's enterprise conversational-AI platform, positioned for businesses to build and deploy chatbots that handle domain-specific tasks — customer service, account questions, loan applications — rather than functioning as a general-purpose assistant. Its core building block is the **action**: a defined task (e.g., "Request a loan") triggered by a set of example phrases, that walks the customer through a scripted conversation step, collecting information and routing to the right outcome.

This is a fundamentally different design philosophy from the assistants already tested in L11 (Siri, Google Assistant) or from a general-purpose model like ChatGPT. Siri and Google Assistant ship with broad, pre-trained conversational ability out of the box. Watson Assistant ships with almost none of that — the business has to build every action, every trigger phrase, and every response step itself before the assistant can do anything. It's less a chatbot and more a chatbot *construction kit*.

2–3. Accessing and Exploring the Demo

The Lendyr Demo (a banking/loan-services assistant) was explored at <https://www.ibm.com/products/watson-assistant/demos/lendyr/demo.html>, alongside the underlying Watson Assistant trial builder that powers it, to see both the customer-facing chat and the business-side setup work required to build it.

Behind the scenes: building an action

The trial builder ships with a pre-built "Request a loan" action as a worked example. Trigger phrases ("Loan information," "I need a loan," "Can we get a loan?," etc.) are what the assistant matches against to recognize the customer's intent, and each conversation step has to be authored manually — including the branching response ("What kind of loan?" → Auto / Home / Student) shown in the preview panel.

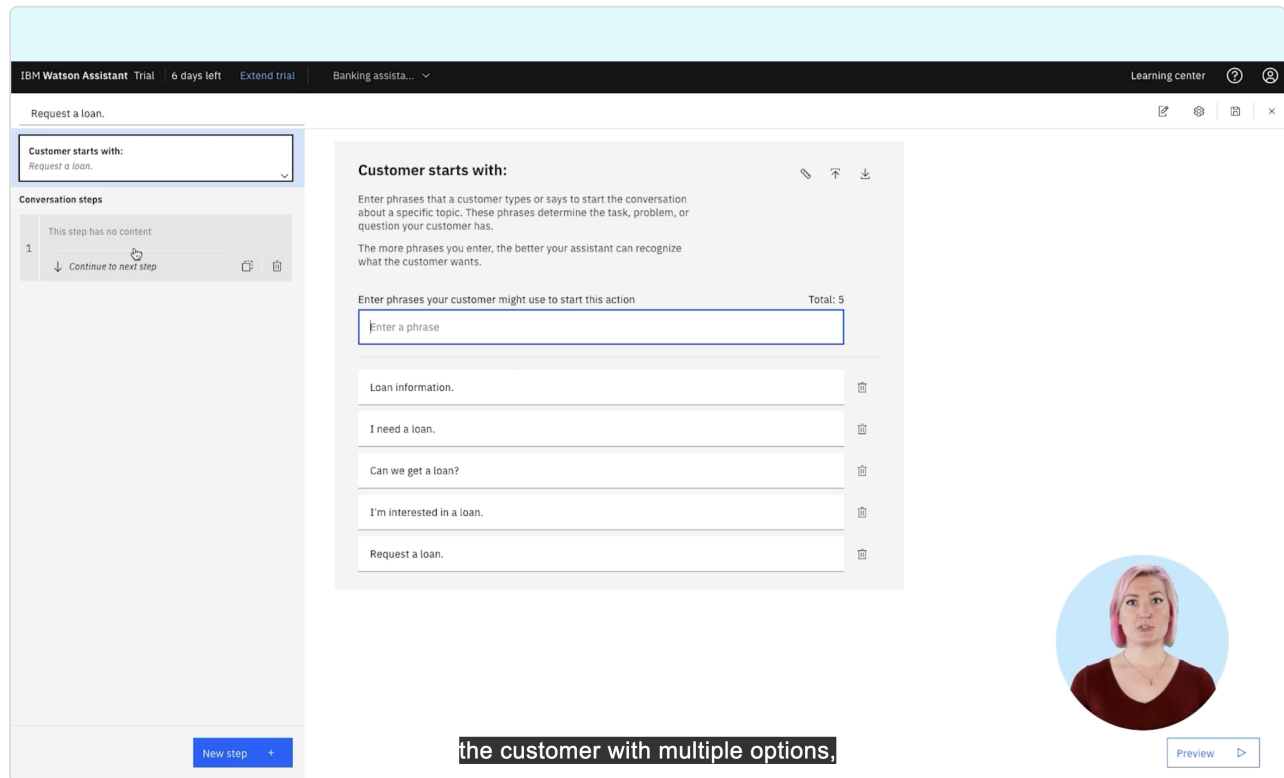


Figure 1 — The "Request a loan" action's trigger-phrase configuration.

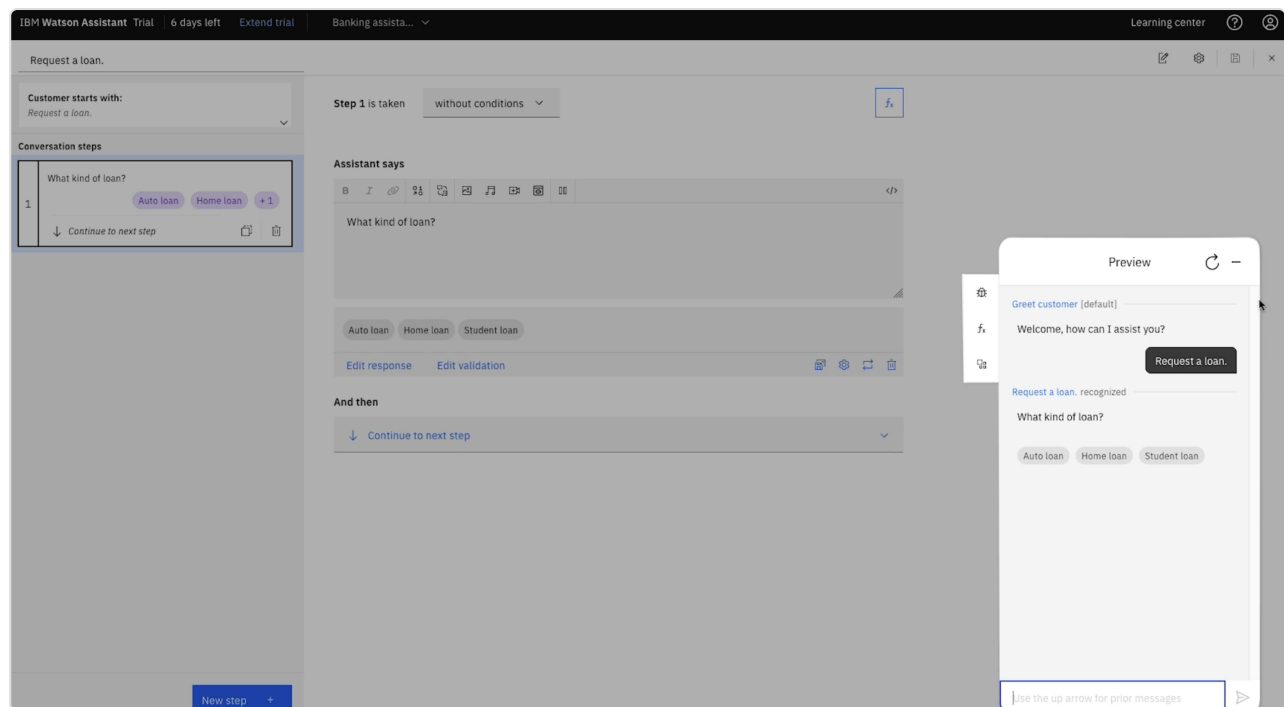


Figure 2 — Live preview: the assistant recognizes "Request a loan" and responds with a branching question (Auto / Home / Student loan).

The platform also exposes a large enterprise integrations catalog (AWS, Google Workspace, Salesforce-adjacent tools, Dropbox, Box, phone/voice connections, and more) — sized for large organizations wiring the assistant into existing business systems.

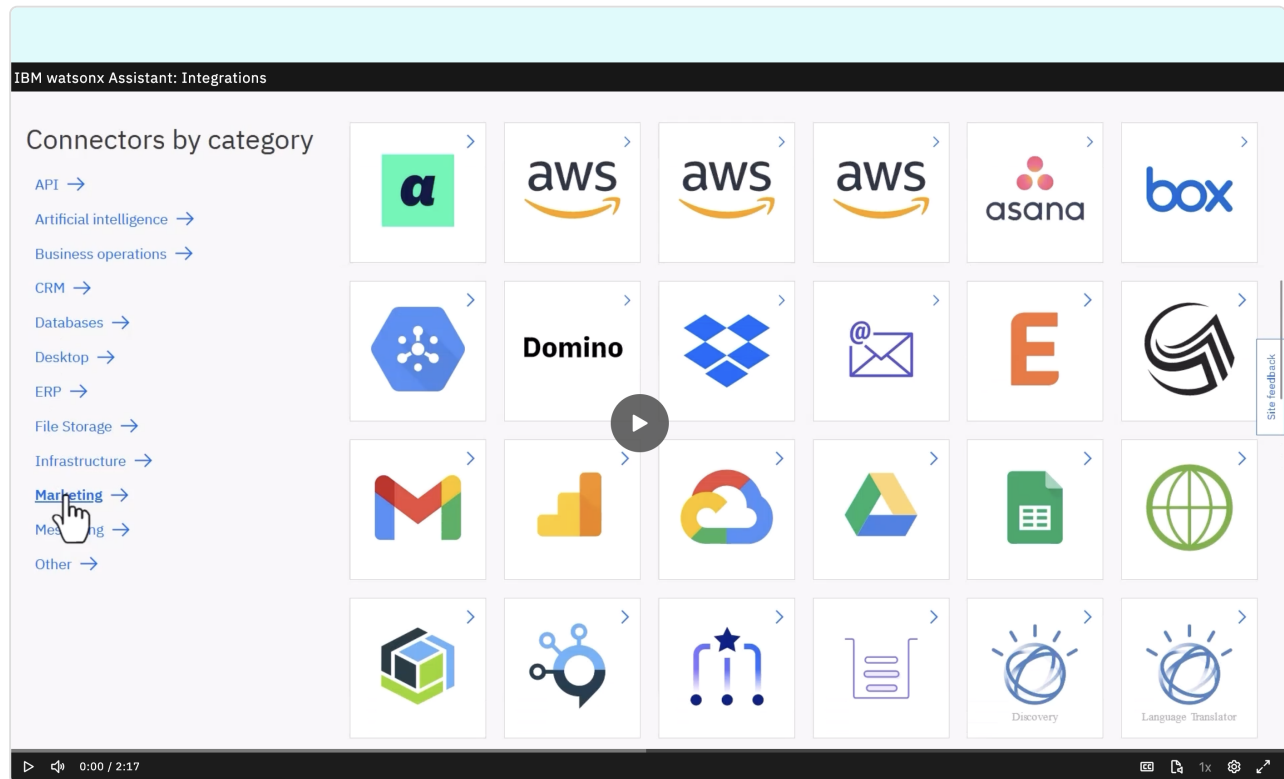


Figure 3 — Watson Assistant's connector catalog, spanning CRM, file storage, cloud infrastructure, and more.

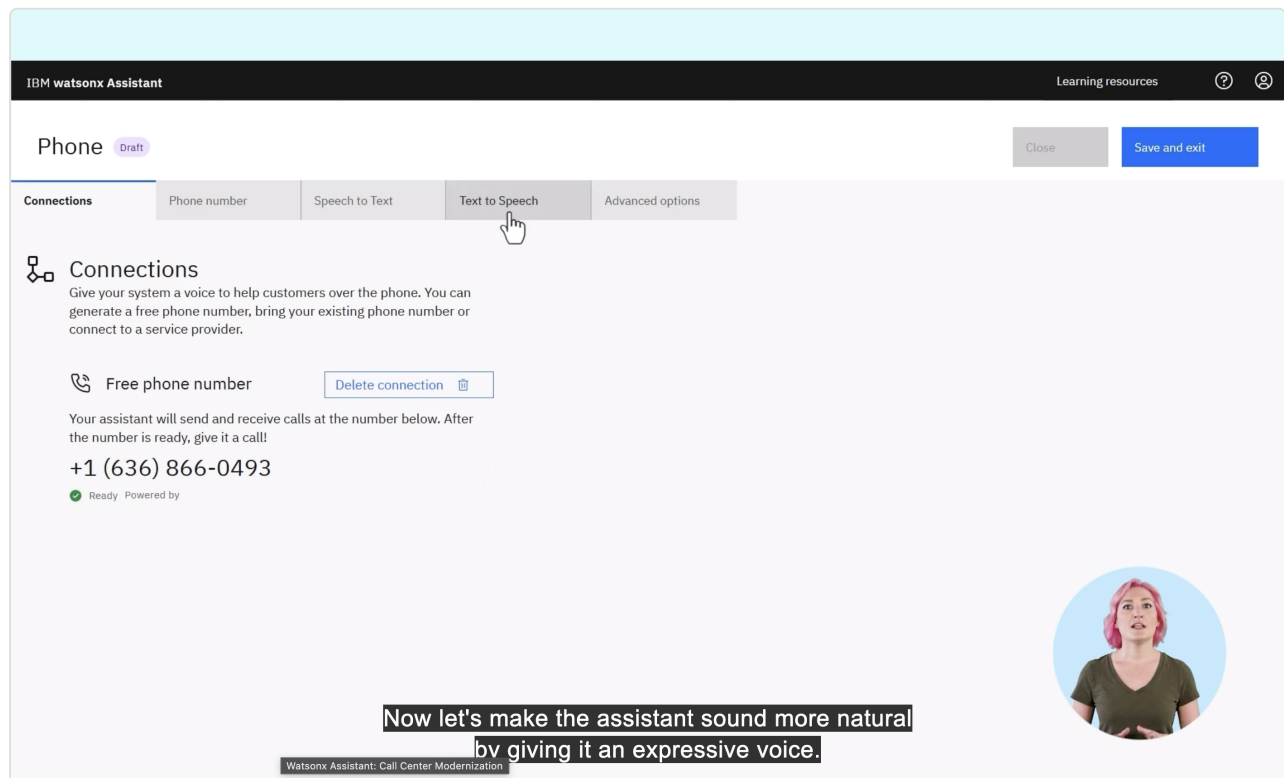


Figure 4 — Phone number + text-to-speech configuration, for deploying the assistant as a voice-based call-center agent.

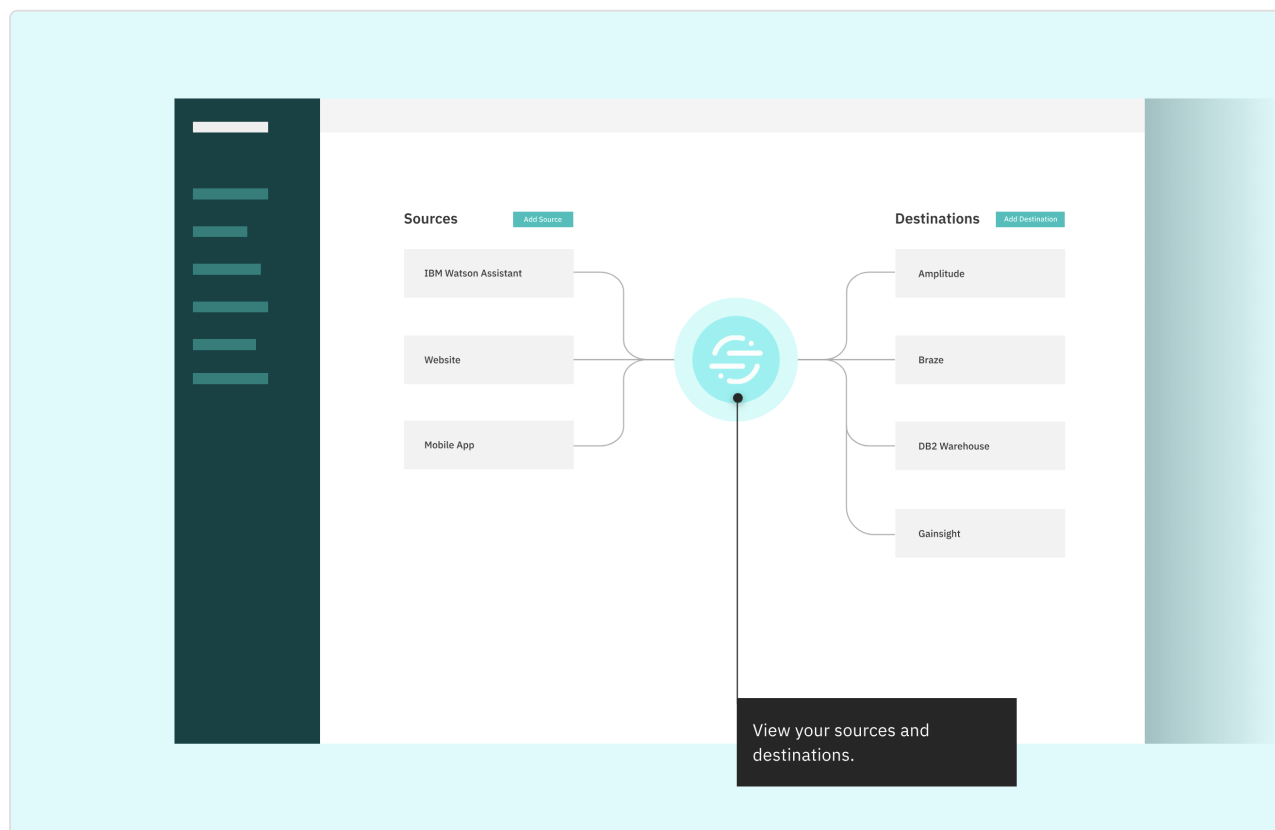


Figure 5 — Watson Assistant as a data source feeding downstream analytics/CRM platforms (Amplitude, Braze, DB2 Warehouse, Gainsight).

The customer-facing conversation

Interacting with the live Lendyr Assistant surfaced both its scripted strengths and a real limitation. Selecting "**Modify in progress application**" from the initial task menu did not lead anywhere useful — the assistant responded that it needed a human agent for that topic, but all agents were offline, and offered only to file a support ticket. This is a concrete example of the chatbot hitting the edge of its scripted scope: anything outside the paths its designers explicitly built terminates in a dead end or a handoff, not a real answer.



Lendyr Assistant



9:24 AM

I can help with the following tasks or questions.
Which best matches what you'd like to accomplish?

Applying for an auto loan

Applying for a home loan

Modify in progress application

None of the above

You 9:24 AM

Modify in progress application



9:24 AM

I need an agent for that topic but all agents are offline. Would you like to file a ticket so someone can respond later?

Yes

No



Figure 6 — Selecting "Modify in progress application" leads to an agent-offline message with no other path forward.

By contrast, staying within the assistant's built script worked well. A student-loan inquiry for a Dental program in Arkansas was handled smoothly — the assistant correctly carried the program type and state across turns and produced an accurate confirmation summary before moving to the next step.



Dental



9:25 AM

What state is the school in?

Arkansas



You 9:25 AM

Arkansas



9:25 AM

Great, let's confirm! Are you a student (or parent) interested in applying for a student loan for a Dental program in the wonderful state of Arkansas?

Yes

No



Figure 7 — A fully in-scope student-loan flow: the assistant tracks program type and state correctly across multiple turns.

IBM's own guided walkthrough also demonstrates the assistant handling mid-conversation topic changes and connecting to a search index for questions outside any pre-built action (e.g., "Can I use my points on airfare?" answered via Search rather than a scripted action).

Ask Clarifying Questions

Request additional input and clarification to help your users find a path to their solution. When the assistant isn't confident enough that a particular action is the best choice, it asks the user a clarifying question to determine the best action to take.

Try it out

- 1 To showcase how intelligent the assistant is when it comes to finding the best answer, let's assume you're looking for financial aid for college.

Start by entering the following:

```
Loan application
```



- 2 The assistant isn't sure what path to take and so offers you some options. In this scenario, none of the options

Change Conversation Topic

Jump around from topic to topic, knowing that the assistant is more than up to the task. Fill in multiple pieces of information – in this case, the type of program, type of loan, and the state of residence – naturally and seamlessly.

Try it out

- 1 Let's jump around a bit and switch topics by entering the following:

How much can we get
in loans?



- 2 You don't have to select an option here. The assistant is able to analyze your answers to send you in the right direction. For instance, try entering the following:

I'm coming from high



Search

Search connects watsonx Assistant to a repository of information (such as your website, content management system, or knowledge base) so the assistant can surface relevant help content your users need.

This time, instead of relying on an action you've created, enter the following to see how the assistant is able to use Search to find answers to questions you've answered elsewhere.

Try it out

- 1 View the default search experience by entering in the following:

```
By the way I'm  
traveling soon. Can I  
use my points on  
airfare?
```



Figures 8–10 — IBM's guided tutorial demonstrating clarifying questions, mid-conversation topic switching, and Search as a fallback for off-action questions.

4. UI/UX Analysis

My assessment, in my own words: This was not intuitive at all, compared to other chatbots I've used. It's very enterprise-focused and business-focused — I can see some consumer use cases, but the setup seemed genuinely complicated. It might have been an innovative approach at some point, but chatbots today are more intuitive and require far less setup work. I didn't like that the customer-facing interaction was mainly narrow inquiries about getting a loan and the different loan types available. Instead of coming with pre-built skills or tools, it felt like you had to orchestrate and essentially build that logic and functionality into the chatbot yourself first — only after that setup work could you actually query it and get a response with real context behind it. Maybe that's innovative from a platform-flexibility standpoint, but to me it felt bulky. It didn't feel fluid, it felt very static, and overall I was unimpressed.

Specific observations:

- **Ease of use:** Low, for anyone without a technical/business-analyst background. The trigger-phrase and conversation-step builder is closer to light programming than a consumer chat setup.
- **Interface design:** Clean and professionally styled, consistent with IBM's enterprise product design language — but that polish is on the *builder* tooling, not on making the underlying task easier.
- **Response time:** Fast within its scripted paths; the moment a request falls outside a built action (the "Modify in progress application" case), the experience collapses to a dead end rather than a graceful fallback.
- **Intuitiveness:** Low. Getting anything beyond the demo's pre-built paths to work would require real setup effort — a stark contrast to general-purpose assistants that respond usefully to almost anything out of the box.

Conclusion

Watson Assistant's real strength and real weakness are the same fact: it's a construction kit, not a ready-made assistant. That earns it genuine flexibility for large enterprises with the resources to build and maintain it — the integrations catalog and voice/phone deployment options are real enterprise capability. But as a hands-on user experience, it felt bulky, static, and dated next to consumer assistants that need zero setup to hold a real conversation. The gap between "impressive enterprise architecture" and "actually pleasant to use" was the clearest takeaway from this exploration.

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